narrow strip of sunlight by the touchline, Victoria beside me. It was getting late: shade stretched away from us across the low curve of the field. It was just our own private party in the place. We had the Bernabeu to ourselves: the stands around us banked like mountain sides, the building work behind us finished for the day. I glanced at Mum. Three months ago, she'd been sitting over there in the far corner, watching me play for United, all her instincts telling her I'd be back to play for Madrid. I headed off towards the penalty area.

'Come on, Brooklyn. Let's score a goal.'

We kicked the ball between us for a minute or two. He seemed tired, a bit distracted. This wasn't Old Trafford. I looked back at Victoria. She was watching Brooklyn. Then she let her glance stray away and around the ground. I thought I knew what she was thinking. This was a time to be brave and I'd found the right girl for that. I caught her eye: a little smile. And then José was saying:

'Shall we go back inside?'

There was a stir backup in the offices. It was time for what we'd come here to do. Senor Perez had arrived. We'd spoken on the phone but this was the first time I'd met the President of Real Madrid. In Spain, the top man at a soccer club is elected by the club's supporters. Senor Perez has a huge building company, one of the biggest in Europe. He's President of one of world soccer's great powers. But he didn't seem to need any of that hanging round his neck like a badge. The really big men have a certain humility about them. You can tell how important Real's President is, and how highly he's thought of, from the respect he's shown by the people around him. He'd never tell you about those things himself. He welcomed me to the Bernabeu and made a point of welcoming Victoria, Brooklyn and Mum to Madrid.

We went through to the boardroom. Everybody from the club was gathered along one side of a long, slightly curving table. They shuffled for a view while Mr and Mrs Beckham and Senor Perez sat down on the other side, the three of us bunched up towards one end. I had the President on my left, Victoria on my right. The paperwork was waiting, laid out in front of us: two neat sets on the pale oak table top. Victoria had given me a beautiful new pen to sign with before we'd left England; she'd also chosen one for the President. Maybe before we sat down would have been the time to give Senor Perez his present. But before we could do anything, he had reached across the table and picked up a ballpoint pen that had been left over from a previous meeting.